

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called 'Excellent Gate'

Ārya-Sumukha-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 614 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་སྐྱོམ་པ་ཞེས་བརྒྱུན་གྱི་ཐུགས་

Toh 614 in the Kangyur is a dhāraṇī text known in English as "The Noble Excellent Gate," corresponding to the Sanskrit Ārya-Sumukha-nāma-dhāraṇī and the Tibetan Phakpa Go Zangpo Zhejawa'i Zung. As a dhāraṇī scripture, it belongs to the broader class of mantra and incantation literature within the Kangyur, presenting a sacred formula along with its narrative and ritual context. The text opens in the classical sūtra style, with the Buddha dwelling at the great stūpa at the site of awakening, surrounded by a vast assembly of monks, great śrāvakas such as Śāradvatīputra and Mahāmaudgalyāyana, and an array of bodhisattvas including Vajrapāṇi, Vajradhvaḥ, Vajragarbha, and Maitreya. This setting among the bodhisattvas of the Fortunate Aeon suggests the text's Mahāyāna orientation, combining the authority of a buddha-word teaching with the protective and liberative power characteristic of the dhāraṇī genre.

In the language of India: Ārya-Sumukha-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the Tibetan language: The dhāraṇī called "The Noble Excellent Gate."

Homage to all buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at the great stūpa of the essence of awakening, beneath the tree of awakening, together with a great Saṅgha of twelve hundred and fifty monks — namely the venerable Śāradvatīputra, the venerable Mahāmaudgalyāyana, and all the other great śrāvakas — and also together with a great Saṅgha of bodhisattvas: the bodhisattva, the great being Vajrapāṇi; the bodhisattva, the great being Vajradhvaḥ; the bodhisattva, the great being Vajragarbha; the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya; and all the other bodhisattvas, great beings, of the Fortunate Aeon.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Vajrapāṇi, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, may the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened buddha, please teach the exposition of the Dharma called 'The Excellent Gate' — that which will bring light to sentient beings, that will guard them against opponents and protect them so that no harm is done to them by all enemies, that will protect them from being frightened by the lords of the gods, the lords of the nāgas, the lords of the yakṣas, the lords of the rākṣasas, and the lords of the spirits, that will prevent harm from evil,

weapons, poison, and sorcery, whether one is going forth or returning, lying down or drifting off to sleep, whether one is confused or utterly confused — that will protect one in all circumstances. For the sake of these ends, may you please teach the bases of such a secret mantra. Just as I constantly seek the service of the Tathāgata, constantly seeking to be guarded and fully protected, may you likewise teach it for the benefit of all sentient beings, and so that sons and daughters of good family who belong to the vehicle of the bodhisattva may be guarded and fully sustained against conflict, slander, quarrel, illness, and untimely death. Thus I beseech the Tathāgata."

Then the Blessed One, having understood the petition made by the bodhisattva, the great being Vajrapāṇi, declared to him thus: "Excellent, excellent, Vajrapāṇi! It is well that you beseech the Tathāgata for the sake of all sentient beings. Therefore, Vajrapāṇi, listen well, and hold this in mind, for I shall teach the exposition of the Dharma called 'The Excellent Gate.'"

Ugu mugu bālinī, bandhani, bālacamanā, bahu bahu bahulibṛtāya svāhā.

The Tathāgata then declared these dhāraṇī mantra bases as a crown empowerment. The Tathāgata, too, will uphold them. He will bestow blessing.

Tadyathā: vajrī vajrī vajrī vajīdhari, vajrapāṇi, vajrīdhari, cakravajri, cakradhari, paṭu dhidhiri, bhiri, muri, cīri, ahuri, bhaga, bhībhiri, śītrā, śīri, ruru ceruru ce, cari cari, dari cale, curi muri, paṇḍare.

Destroyer of all evil, pacifier of all illness, averter of untimely death — averter of all the way down to evil dreams.

Tadyathā: bandhida, gagaraṇi, murtani, pramurtani, nāśani, pranāśani.

Pacifier of all illness, averter all the way down to evil dreams.

Tadyathā: nāśani, nāśani, bandhani, bandhani, cchindani, cchindani, cire mire, mahehādani, banivare, khare bere, biri biri, bodhi bodhi, suṣaṇi, śaraṇi, varuvariṇi, par hūṃ ye, brahmacāriṇi, indravati, dhidhirīyaṇi, namo maheśvarayaṇi, ṛṣi, bañjani, pāpajahani, kālapatini, bhūtapadani, satyagathe, somavādi, somaprabhe svāhā.

One's life shall be lengthened.

Tadyathā: hara hara hara hāṇi svāhā.

Tadyathā: iḍita gaḍita vadida, ayena, arī bañjanika kākīrtani, putradat hāni, marga abhirohani, husavati, mupavati, hili hili, yathā pajuya, yathā agni yathā varanaca, yathā nala, yathā nala, yathā vajraṇa, yathā hṛdaya svāhā.

Vajrapāṇi, this is the dhāraṇī called the Good Gateway. It was taught out of the compassion of the Tathāgatas for the benefit of sentient beings. Just as the Tathāgatas, the fully and perfectly awakened buddhas of former times, proclaimed it, blessed it, and established it with the solemn pledge of truth, so too shall I now teach it.

Thereupon a ray of light went forth from the Blessed One's ūṣṇā hair-mark between the brows, one of the marks that adorn a great being, and illumination spread throughout all the buddha fields. Summoned by that illumination, beings set out from their respective buddha fields and came to this world-realm called Sahā. There they offered the expression "Excellent!" to the Blessed One Śākyamuni, saying: "Excellent! Excellent, Śākyamuni! For the benefit of all sentient beings you have illuminated, caused supreme delight in, brought to mind, and taught this Dharma category of dhāraṇī mantra bases called the Good Gateway. We too shall bless it." And so they gave the expression of Excellent.

Whatever son or daughter of good family holds these dhāraṇī mantra bases and, rising in the morning, recites them — that son or daughter of good family should understand the twenty benefits and virtues thereof. What are the twenty? They are these: one will be blessed by all buddhas; one will be regarded with care by all buddhas; all karmic obscurations that would lead to the lower states will be utterly eliminated; one's life will be lengthened; one will live long and possess renown; one will be endowed with resources; one will be endowed with strength; one will be endowed with splendor; one will always be endowed with good health; one will be endowed with diligence; all buddhas, the Blessed Ones, will be pleased and will receive one with satisfaction; all gods will think of one; one will conduct oneself virtuously; one will be earnestly devoted to virtuous aims; one will become illumined, filled with supreme joy, and endowed with mindfulness; one will be endowed with excellent marks; one will be fearless; and one will be endowed with all roots of virtue.

Vajrapāṇi, these dhāraṇī mantra bases of the secret place were proclaimed by the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the fully and perfectly awakened buddhas, and they have been blessed by all buddhas.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Vajrapāṇi, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I too will protect, guard, and attend upon whatever son or daughter of good family

I will proclaim these dhāraṇī mantra bases for the sake of protecting and thoroughly attending upon whoever holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra belonging to the Dharma category called "The Excellent Gate," and who rises at dawn to recite it. I will guard that person from all harm.

Thus: Shikhi shikhi shikhi shika, tsi tsi tsi tsi, bha bha bha bha, ru ru ru ru, dzi dzi dzi, gra gra gra gra, hri hri hri hri, ha ha ha ha, ma ma ma ma, hana hana me, sarva pratyarthakā, daha daha me, sarva śatrāva, paca paca me, sarva ahiteṣṇa svāhā.

Then the Blessed One praised the bodhisattva, the great being Vajrapāṇi, with the words "Excellent!" — "Excellent, Vajrapāṇi! For the sake of all sentient beings you have proclaimed these dhāraṇī mantra bases of supreme spiritual attainment."

The bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi then addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, I will further proclaim these dhāraṇī mantra bases for the sake of protecting and thoroughly attending upon whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it — I will grant all radiance into their very pores."

Thus: Hili mili tsili svāhā. Brahmasvāre svāhā. Brahma avasugarbhe akalpe, puṣa saṃstare svāhā.

"Blessed One, these are the dhāraṇī mantra bases for the protection and thorough attendance upon whatever son or daughter of good family rises at dawn to recite this text."

Then Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I too will proclaim these dhāraṇī mantra bases, blessed by the buddhas, for the sake of protecting and thoroughly attending upon whatever son or daughter of good family holds these life-protecting vidyā mantras and rises at dawn to recite them."

Thus: Bodhicitte, varaṇi, damāraṇaḍe, ditti ditti, gauri, gandhāri, sarmatanta, vajratulani, jvālamālini, cakravāka, śavare śavare, śamare śamare svāhā.

Then the four great kings — the Great King Vaiśravaṇa, the Great King Dhṛtarāṣṭra, the Great King Virūḍhaka, and the Great King Virūpākṣa — bowed with joined palms toward the Blessed One and addressed him with these words: "Blessed One, we four great kings as well will recite this dhāraṇī secret mantra for the sake of protecting and thoroughly attending upon whatever son

or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Puṣpe supuṣpe, śodhani, saṃśodhani, dhūmavare hare, āryapraśaste, śānte, nirmukte, maṃgalye, hiraṇyagarbhe stara stapa svāhā.

Then the great mother of elemental spirits, Māmakī the Seizer, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I too will recite these dhāraṇī secret mantra bases for the sake of protecting and thoroughly attending upon whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate,' rises at dawn to recite it, and takes it to heart."

Thus: Pili sipbili, sili, mahā pipili, simeli si, guruṇe, guru guṇe, mahā kuruṇe phu svāhā.

Then the five great yakṣa commanders, the rtsens, bowed with joined palms toward the Blessed One and addressed him with these words:

"Venerable Blessed One, I too will protect whatever son or daughter of good family holds this Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Aṭṭhe phu, baṭṭhe phu, naṭṭhe phu, kunaṭṭhe phu, manaṭṭha phu, muṭṭatahake phu, śrī phu, bhaṃge phu, maṃke phu svāhā.

Then the great bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will protect whatever son or daughter of good family holds this Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it. I will thoroughly tend, thoroughly hold, thoroughly shelter, pacify, bring to wellbeing, remove harm, neutralize poison, and establish boundaries for that person."

Thus: He vajre, he vajre, hī hā, bi si bi si, mahā bi si phu svāhā.

Then the divine son Maheśvara, the Great God (Śiva), bowed with joined palms toward the Blessed One and addressed him with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will recite these dhāraṇī mantra bases for the sake of protecting and thoroughly tending whatever son or daughter of good family holds this Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Hulu hulu hulu hulu lu lu, sarva bhūta pratiṣedhanaṃ karomi svāhā.

Then the young commander bowed with joined palms toward the Blessed One and addressed him with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will recite these dhāraṇī mantra bases for the sake of protecting and thoroughly tending whatever son or daughter of good family holds this pure Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Hi li hi li, hi li hi li, hi li hi li, mi li mi li, turu turu, turu turu, sarva bhūta pratiṣedhanaṃ karomi svāhā.

Then the divine son Candraprabha bowed with joined palms toward the Blessed One and addressed him with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will protect and thoroughly tend whatever son or daughter of good family holds this pure Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Aṃge, baṃge, caṃge hini, ḍiḍi, didi, cici phu svāhā.

Then the great bodhisattva, the noble Avalokiteśvara, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will protect and thoroughly tend whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Hate, bihate, nihate, sarva pratyā, rīkā pratyā, mitra śuddhe, mukte, bimukti, bimale, nirmale prabhāsvare, prabhākare phu svāhā.

Then the great bodhisattva Maitreya addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will protect whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Jvale jvale, mahā jvale, jvaleni, ukke, mukke, śame, praśame, mahā praśame, śame samādhe, mahā samādhe, samāvadhe, jvale —

mahā jvale, jvale bame phu svāhā.

Then the yakṣa (Skt. yakṣa) commander Himavat joined his palms together, bowed in the direction of the Blessed One, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will protect and fully guard whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Udumbare, udumbare, dumbe, pradumbe, byābrde, ānaghe, samādhe, mahā samādhe, nīle nīle, nīlakeśe, keśini, kule kule, mahā kule, nīlakule, siddhi, siddhe, manohāre, aṭṭe, baṭṭe, naṭṭe, kunaṭṭe, samathe, bavala, kuce, dānte, nīlakaśe, kule, nīla, dhante, jāṃgule, huśe, mūśe, balaṃkuśe, halakuśe, phalamuce svāhā.

Then the great yakṣa commander Sukhāvāsagiri joined his palms together, bowed in the direction of the Blessed One, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will protect and fully guard whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Amale, vimale, nirmale, maṃgale, hiraṇyagarbhe, sarva arthasādhani, kamaṣṭini, yuvirāje, kuṭakuṭa, kaṃbale, brahma, brahmasvare, brahmasiddhe, siddhi manorate phu svāhā.

Then the great goddess Vajraluguryud joined her palms together, bowed in the direction of the Blessed One, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will protect, guard, shelter, hold, and fully nurture whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it, and for their sake I shall recite the root dhāraṇī mantras."

Thus: Vajre, vajre, mahā vajre, vajradani, buddha vajra, buddha adhiṣṭhite vajre, subuddhe, nibuddhe, bahubuddhe, viśiṣṭabuddhe, śuddhe, buddhe, buddhe, nīśaṃgrāmaṇi, jaṃgele, alase, telime, tile, tilile, marge, śānta, śānta, gāmini phu svāhā.

Then the great bodhisattva Vajrasena addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable Blessed One, I too will protect whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Hile vajre, hihi vajre, hehe vajra, yavakiri kiri vajra svāhā. Thus: Aṇḍare, paṇḍare, śvete, paṇḍaravāsini, kinnare, karāde, keyūre, iha buddhe, tattva buddhe, bhūje bhūje, bhūjaṃgame, bhūjapāpate, bhaye bhaye, bhaya agravate, vinī vinī, śiripate, śivapate, ādityapate, teje tejāvato, ākāśapate phu svāhā.

Then the vajra messenger joined her palms together, bowed in the direction of the Blessed One, and addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Venerable

Blessed One, I too will protect, guard, and conceal whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it."

Thus: Kuṭe kuṭe, kuṭini, kuṭakuṭare svāhā. Nīli nīle —

nīlakeśe svāhā. Pīte pīte, pītakeśe svāhā. Lohite lohite, lohitakeśe svāhā. Avadāde avadāde, avadātakeni svāhā. Mañjiṣṭhe mañjiṣṭhe, mañjiṣṭhakeśe svāhā. Cakre cakre, vajracakre svāhā.

Then the Blessed One extended his right hand, golden in color, and gave his approval — saying "Excellent!" — to Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), to Brahmā, and to all the world-protectors. With the blessing of the Tathāgata he declared: "Excellent! Excellent, O gods and world-protectors! For the benefit and protection of all sentient beings, you have recited well these dhāraṇī mantra bases."

Then the Blessed One again addressed the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi: "Vajrapāṇi, whatever son or daughter of good family holds this life-protecting vidyā mantra of the Dharma category called 'The Excellent Gate' and rises at dawn to recite it — that person will be blessed by all the buddhas. The lord of the gods, the lord of the nāgas, the lord of the yakṣas, the lord of the asuras, the lord of the garuḍas, the lord of the kiṃnaras, and all the lords of the great serpents will think upon that person with favor."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the bodhisattva Vajrapāṇi, Śakra, Brahmā, all the world-protectors together with their retinues, and the entire world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had proclaimed.

The noble dhāraṇī called "The Excellent Gate" is complete.

Translated by the Indian scholars Jinamitra and Dānaśīla, together with the great editor

Translator's Notes

- The names Vajradhvaja and Vajragarbha are reconstructed from the Tibetan: རྩམ་བྱེད་ཀླུ་མ་ལྷ་མོ་ means "Vajra-Banner" (Vajradhvaja) and རྩམ་བྱེད་ཀླུ་མ་ལྷ་མོ་ means "Vajra-Essence" (Vajragarbha). These are stock bodhisattva names in the Fortunate Aeon list.

The mantra syllables are rendered in approximate phonetic transliteration consistent with their Tibetan orthography. The Sanskrit underlying these dhāraṇī phrases is formulaic and not always fully recoverable; no attempt has been made to normalize or correct them beyond faithful phonological rendering.

The phrase rendered "crown empowerment" (spyi bo nas dbang bskur) literally means "empowerment from the crown of the head," indicating an abhiṣeka-style bestowal transmitted through the head.

- The phrase translated as "ūrṇā hair-mark between the brows" renders the Tibetan རྒྱུ་རྩིས་གོ་བློ་མཚན་པུ་ལྷོ་འཕྲུ་ཆེན་པོ།, literally "the treasury-hair at the brow-junction," which corresponds to the Sanskrit ūrṇā, one of the thirty-two major marks of a great being. This is standard.

The phrase "secret place" for 秘密處 is here a doctrinal designation for this particular class or category of dhāraṇī, not a topographical location; some editions treat it as a proper title of the collection. The ambiguity is real but does not substantially affect the meaning for a listener.

- The term 摩利支天 is a complex deity name. 摩利支 refers to a class of wrathful female spirits, and 天 means "the Seizing One" or "the Snatcher." Rendered here as "the great mother of elemental spirits, Māmāki the Seizer" to convey both the class of being and the epithet, though the precise identity of this figure is uncertain.

The word 𑖦𑖪𑖫𑖫 before the five great yakṣa commanders is obscure; it may be a proper name, a title, or a textual anomaly. It is left in transliteration pending further clarification.

- The phrase rendered "young commander" translates the Tibetan "sde dpon gzhon nu," literally "youthful captain of the host." The identity of this figure is not specified in the passage; it may refer to Kārttikeya (Kumāra), the young divine general, which would fit the context of a list of divine protectors, but the text does not make this explicit.

The mantra phrase "sarva bhūta pratiṣedhanaṃ karomi" means roughly "I perform the warding off of all harmful spirits," and appears twice with different preceding syllables; the rendering is kept consistent with both occurrences.

The passage ends mid-mantra, as the source text breaks off at "jvale," indicating this is a continuing passage.

- The name rendered "Himavat" for the yakṣa commander is a reconstruction from the Tibetan "Kha ba can," meaning "one who has snow," the standard Tibetan equivalent of the Sanskrit Himavat. The name rendered "Sukhāvāsagiri" for the great yakṣa commander is a reconstruction from the Tibetan "bde ba'i ri gnas," meaning "dwelling on the mountain of bliss." The great goddess name "Vajraluguryud" is a transliteration of the Tibetan "rdo rje lu gu rgyud," which may represent a Sanskrit original now difficult to recover with certainty; it may mean something like "Vajra Chain" or "Vajra Garland." The bodhisattva "Vajrasena" renders "rdo rje'i sde," literally "vajra host" or "vajra army."

- The closing colophon is cut off mid-sentence; the text ends with "the great editor" and the name of the Tibetan editor-translator (lo tsā ba) has not been supplied in the input. This is a standard Tibetan canonical colophon formula and is simply incomplete here. The terms "lord of the garuḍas" and "lord of the kimnaras" render ཀུརུཊ་ལོ་རྒྱལ་པོ་ and ཀིམ་ན་ར་ལོ་རྒྱལ་པོ་ respectively; kimnaras are semi-divine musical beings of ambiguous form.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the

Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.